

# Understand Zillow Home Loans and practice buyer introductions

63 minutes including practice · 26 screens

Edition 2026-09-17-day4-two-sections-v11

## Your Day 4 teaching reference

Use these explanations and demonstrations after class. Follow the 2 sections to find the task you need. Complete interactive record practice in Rep. Fictional examples illustrate the steps.

### Zillow Home Loans and the buyer introduction

Day Four · 63 minutes including discussion and breakout practice

Understand what ZHL offers. Learn when an introduction fits the buyer's plans, then practice connecting the buyer and loan officer at the end of the first appointment.

### Today's training has two parts

Discuss first, learn the process, then practice saying it aloud.

- 01Zillow Home Loans overviewLoan options, affordability tools, approval stages and working with a loan officer.
- 02Buyer introductions and breakout practiceDecide whether now is the right time, ask permission, make the connection and confirm the call.

### Zillow Home Loans overview

Start with what you value in a lender. Then learn how ZHL supports the buyer and the transaction.

01

Discuss your experience

Learn the steps

Explain what you learned

### What Zillow Home Loans does

Zillow Home Loans is Zillow's affiliated mortgage lender.

### For the buyer

A loan officer reviews financing options, explains the payment and cash needed, and guides the loan process. ZHL offers purchase and refinance loans.

### For the agent

You coordinate property questions, financing progress and transaction deadlines with the loan officer. The loan officer determines loan eligibility and approval.

## For this training

Learn what ZHL provides so you can explain the reason for an introduction. The buyer decides which lender to use.

[Zillow Home Loans overview](#) ■ · Reviewed September 17, 2026

## Know the loan options you can ask ZHL about

Name the option, then let the loan officer explain whether it fits this buyer.

### Conventional

A mortgage without a federal government guarantee. Ask about available fixed-rate and adjustable-rate options.

### FHA

Insured by the Federal Housing Administration. Ask about down payment and mortgage insurance when comparing it with a conventional loan.

### VA

For eligible veterans, service members and certain surviving spouses. The loan officer confirms eligibility and explains any funding fee.

### Jumbo

A loan above the applicable conforming limit. Ask which limit applies to the property and what ZHL requires for the larger amount.

Published terms include 10-, 15-, 20- and 30-year fixed loans; 20-, 25- and 30-year FHA; and 30-year VA and jumbo. Confirm which terms apply to the buyer. Next: the 7/6 ARM and 2-1 buydown.

[Current loan types and availability](#) ■ · Reviewed September 17, 2026

[What the loan types mean](#) ■ · Reviewed September 17, 2026

## Compare fixed and adjustable rates

ZHL offers both. Compare the starting payment and what can change later.

### The rate stays the same

Principal and interest stay level for the loan term. Taxes and insurance can still change the total payment.

## Ask the loan officer

“How do the payment and total cost compare across the available terms?”

### Fixed first. Adjustable later.

The rate stays fixed for seven years, then can change every six months under the loan's terms.

## Ask the loan officer

“How much could the rate and payment increase, and what limits apply?”

For an ARM, review the possible later payment - not just the starting payment. Do not assume the buyer can sell or refinance before the rate changes.

## How the 2-1 buydown changes the payment

ZHL's program provides temporary payment relief during the first two years.

### 2 percentage points lower

### 1 percentage point lower

### Full loan rate

The first two years' payments use a reduced rate for the calculation. The rate in the loan agreement stays the same; the temporary subsidy ends after year two.

A buyer wants lower early payments, or a seller is offering a credit. Ask the loan officer whether a seller-paid buydown fits the loan.

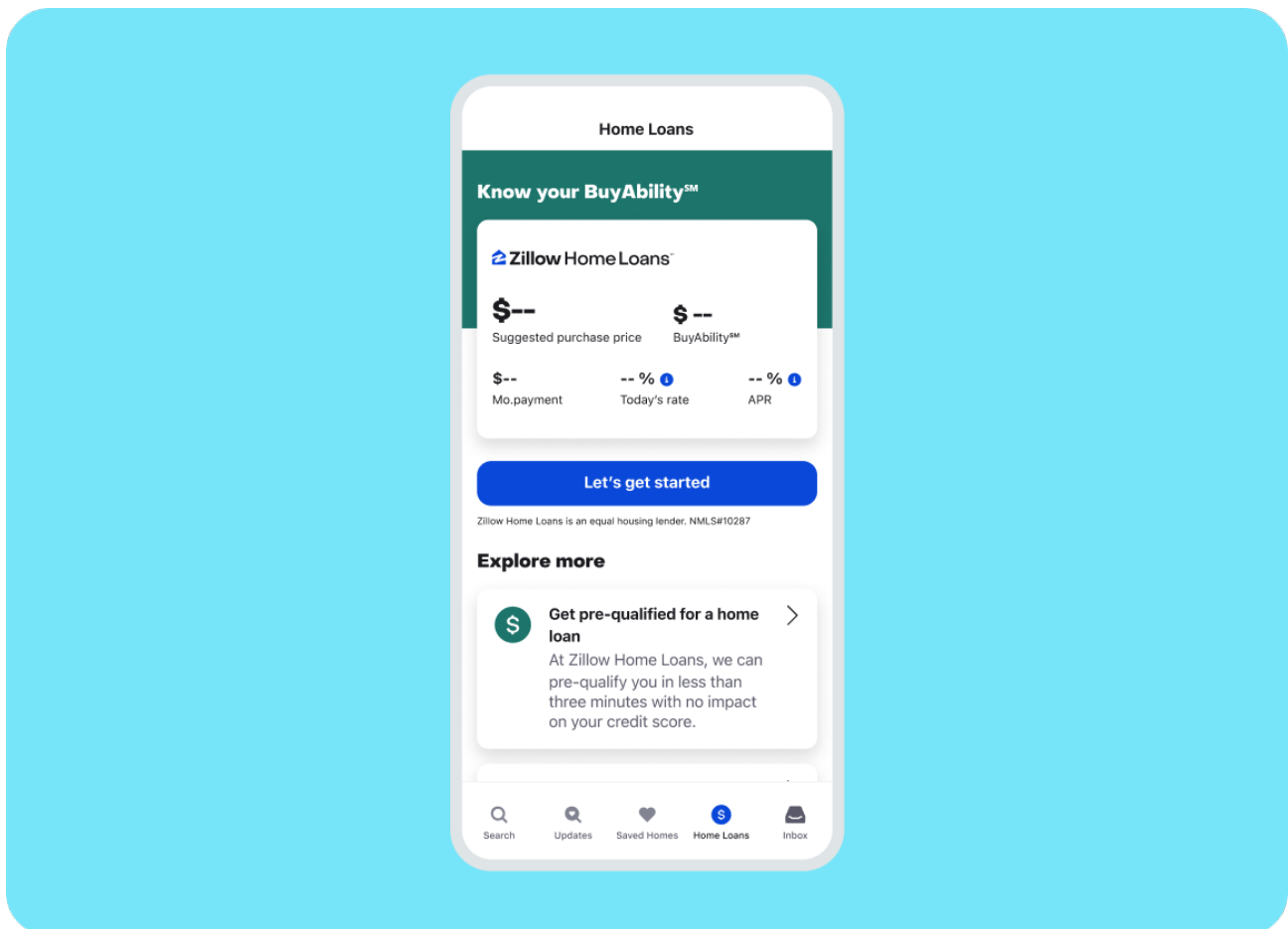
Who pays for it? What does it cost? What will the full payment be in year three? Compare other uses of the seller credit.

The buyer must understand the full payment. A future refinance is not guaranteed.

ZHL's official buydown handout and payment example ■

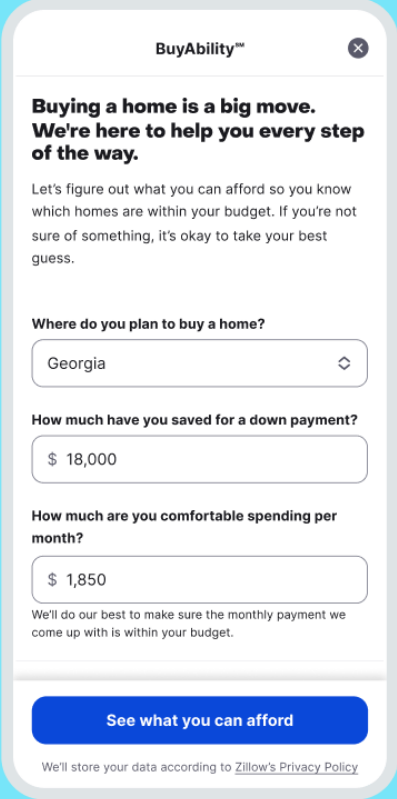
## What buyers see in BuyAbility

Buyers use this tool themselves to explore what they may be able to afford.



## 01Where buyers start

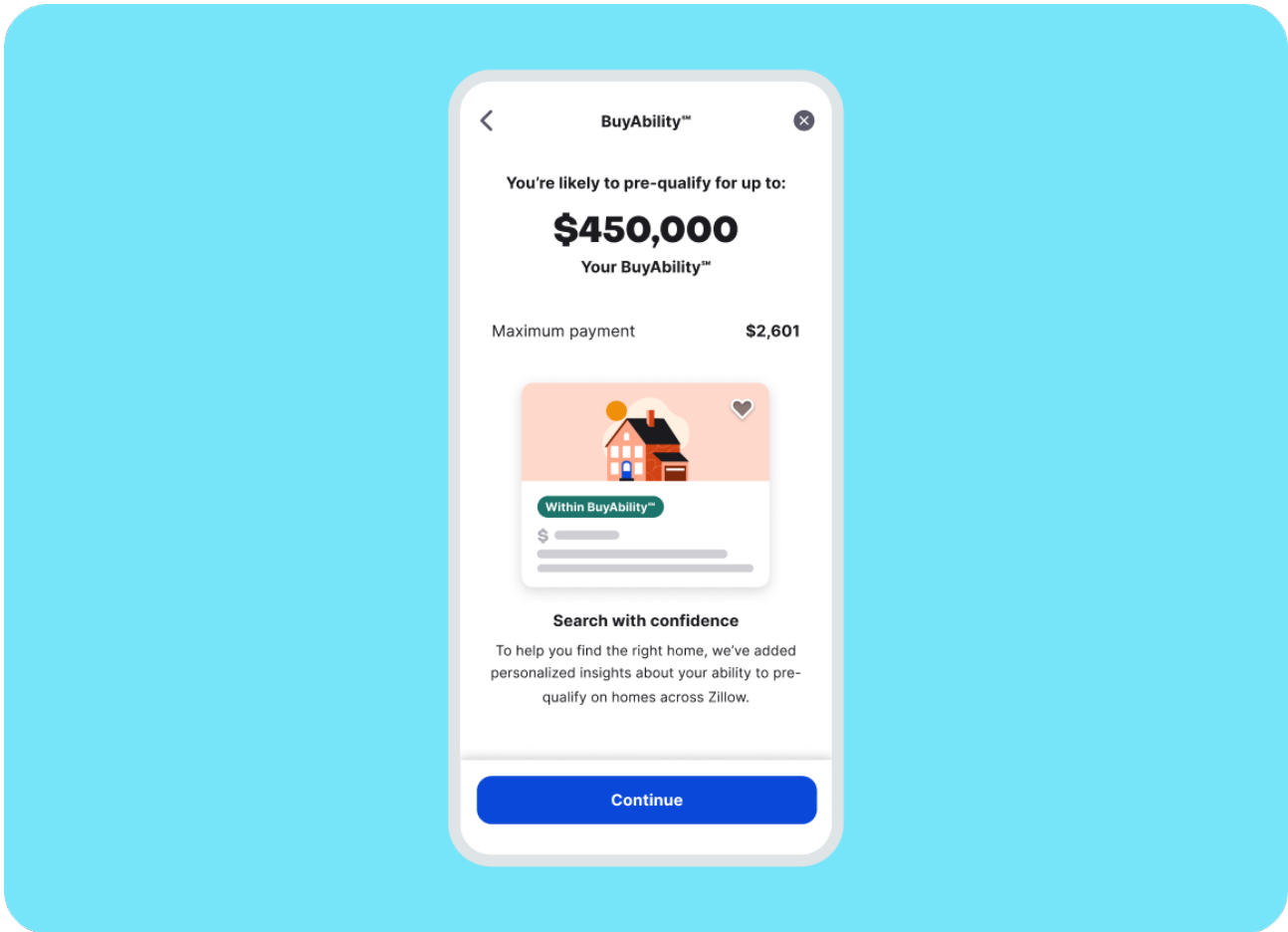
Buyers can find BuyAbility in Zillow's Home Loans tab.



The screenshot displays the BuyAbility mobile app interface. At the top, the header reads "BuyAbility™" with a close button (X) on the right. Below the header, a bold statement says: "Buying a home is a big move. We're here to help you every step of the way." This is followed by a paragraph: "Let's figure out what you can afford so you know which homes are within your budget. If you're not sure of something, it's okay to take your best guess." The form then asks "Where do you plan to buy a home?" with a dropdown menu showing "Georgia". Next, it asks "How much have you saved for a down payment?" with a text input field containing "\$ 18,000". Then, it asks "How much are you comfortable spending per month?" with a text input field containing "\$ 1,850". Below these inputs is a paragraph: "We'll do our best to make sure the monthly payment we come up with is within your budget." At the bottom of the form is a large blue button labeled "See what you can afford". At the very bottom of the app screen, there is a small line of text: "We'll store your data according to [Zillow's Privacy Policy](#)".

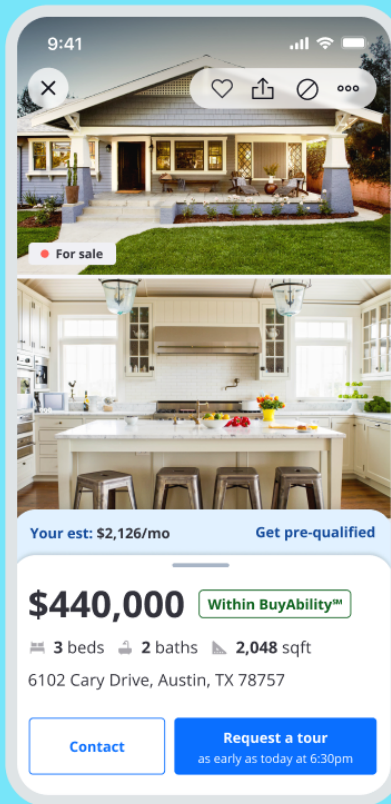
## 02What buyers enter

Location, savings and a comfortable monthly payment help inform the estimate.



**03What buyers see**

An estimated purchase amount and payment give buyers a starting point.



## 04How it appears in search

“Within BuyAbility” identifies homes within the estimated purchasing power.

## What this means for the agent

A buyer may arrive with a BuyAbility number in mind. Recognize where that number came from: it is an estimate based on buyer inputs, not verified loan approval. The loan officer reviews the buyer’s financing.

Zillow’s demonstration screens; figures are illustrative. Source ■ · Select any screen to view the original.

## Understand the stages before calling a buyer approved

Ask what the lender has reviewed and what still needs to happen.

### Pre-qualification

An initial estimate using self-reported income and assets plus a soft credit check. It does not mean the documents have all been verified.

### Verified pre-approval

The lender verifies income, assets and credit. ZHL describes a soft-pull option; confirm the inquiry type and remaining conditions with the loan officer.

## Final approval and funding

The lender must complete the remaining borrower and property requirements. A pre-approval letter does not guarantee funding.

[ZHL pre-qualification and pre-approval FAQ](#) ■ · Reviewed September 17, 2026

## How ZHL reviews credit during pre-approval

Pre-approval includes verification of income, assets and credit.

## Soft-pull pre-approval

ZHL describes a pre-approval option that uses a soft credit inquiry. That inquiry does not affect the buyer's credit score.

## When an earlier hard pull may help

If the buyer is close to the loan program's minimum credit score, the loan officer may recommend a hard pull before issuing the letter. The purpose is to resolve eligibility concerns before the buyer shops relying on that approval.

## What to confirm with the loan officer

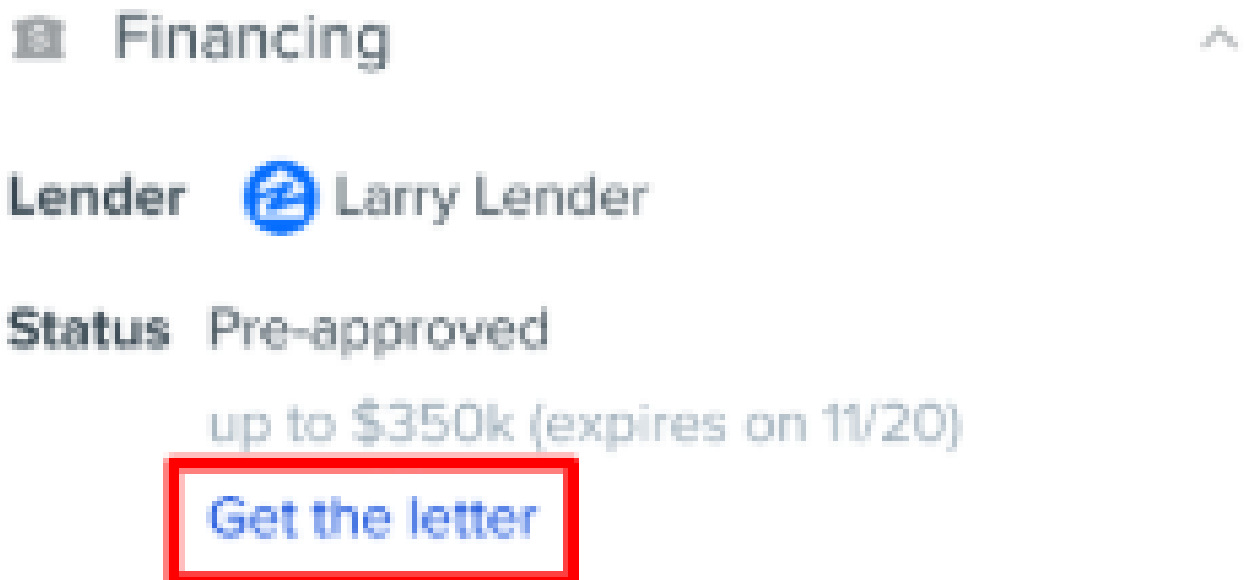
Ask: "Does this buyer need a hard pull before you issue the pre-approval? What minimum score applies to their program?" Confirm the answer before describing the credit check to the buyer.

A soft inquiry and a hard inquiry are different. A hard inquiry can affect the credit score. The loan officer determines when it is needed; do not assume it always waits until the buyer is ready to make an offer.

[ZHL soft-pull pre-approval explanation](#) ■ · [ZHL FAQ](#) ■

## Check financing progress in Follow Up Boss

Open the buyer's profile. Find Financing on the left side.



## Read the status and approval details

Check the financing status and last update. When pre-approved, review the amount and expiration date. Select **Get the letter** to access the latest letter.

### Financing

Lender  Larry Lender

Status **Buyer unresponsive**

No reply: 5 attempts (last today)

[Contact Beth](#)

## Notice when the buyer needs follow-up

FUB can show loan officer outreach and an unresponsive-buyer status. Use the contact link to review the suggested message and help the buyer reconnect.

The Zillow two-way integration and your linked Zillow profile are required. After the lender is assigned, status updates help you follow progress from initial contact through funding. If the information is unclear, contact the loan officer.

Official Follow Up Boss examples; names, amounts and dates are sample content from the source. [View instructions](#)

## Find and download the verified pre-approval

A notification opens the buyer's profile. The letter is also available from Financing or the timeline.



**Customize the price shown on your letter**

Enter a price between \$150,000 and the current purchase price. The letter will show a loan amount and down payment that add up to that price. For other changes, contact your loan officer.

Expires on: March 15, 2025

Max loan amount: \$200,000

Current purchase price: \$250,000

Price to display on letter: **\$200,000**

This preview does not include real info.

**Zillow HomeLoans**

**Congratulations on your Verified Pre-approval!**

| Pre-Approved Applicant(s) | Purchase Price | Loan Type |
|---------------------------|----------------|-----------|
| First name Last name      | \$250,000.00   | 30Y       |

Issue Date: December 6, 2024

Loan Amount: \$200,000.00

Subject Property: TBD

Down Payment: \$50,000.00

The number you enter will show up here

[Download letter](#)

## Review and download

On eligible desktop letters, enter a price within the permitted range and select **Download letter**. Check the downloaded letter before using it.

Only the assigned agent can download; this feature requires a Zillow-connected lead. If the letter has expired or customization is unavailable, contact the loan officer.

Official Follow Up Boss examples; names, amounts and dates are sample content from the source. [View instructions](#)

## Confirm these details before relying on financing

Keep the knowledge from the earlier slides attached to a specific buyer and property.

## Payment and cash

“What payment and cash to close should this buyer plan for at this price?” Ask what is included in the estimate.

## Remaining requirements

“What documents or conditions remain? Does this property change the loan review?”

## Deadlines and communication

“Can you support the proposed closing date? What do you need from us, and when will you update us?” Save the answer before relying on that timing.

## **Introduce the buyer and practice the connection**

At the end of the first appointment, decide whether an introduction would help now. Learn the short conversation, then practice it.

02

Discuss your experience

Learn the steps

Practice in breakout rooms

## **Decide whether a lender introduction fits the timing**

TRU's introduction guidance: confirm the buyer's plans before transferring the lead.

### **Buying within six months**

If the buyer wants to purchase, has a financing question and wants help, offer an introduction. A short timeline alone is not permission to transfer.

### **More than six months away**

Usually continue agent follow-up rather than transfer now. At twelve months out, ask what sets the timing, save the reason and agree when to revisit financing.

### **Already supported or not interested**

If they have a lender and do not want another conversation, respect that. Confirm what is already in progress and continue working with their chosen lender.

This is TRU's timing guidance, not a ZHL lending requirement. If a buyer asks for financing advice earlier, clarify the question and offer a conversation when it would help.

### **Ask about the buyer's plan when they raise a credit concern**

Do not automatically transfer someone because they mention a credit problem.

### **No near-term purchase or request for help**

Ask when they expect to buy and whether they want help now. If they are not ready to act, agree on a follow-up date instead of sending an unexpected lender referral.

### **Wants to buy soon and asks about options**

For "I want to buy in three months and need to know what is possible," offer a loan-officer conversation about eligibility and steps. Confirm that they want the introduction.

*"Are you looking for help understanding your options now, or would you rather revisit this closer to when you're ready?"*

Let the loan officer assess credit and loan eligibility. Do not promise approval, a workaround or a credit-repair timeline.

### **Offer the introduction at the end of the appointment**

First ask: "Have you already spoken with a lender about your budget?"

*“Since you’re hoping to buy in the next three months, it would help to know what payment you’re comfortable with and what you can qualify for. I work with a loan officer at Zillow Home Loans. Would you like me to introduce you?”*

*“Would you prefer a group text or email? What time would be good for a call?”*

Use their answer in the introduction. Ask the loan officer to confirm the time before telling the buyer it is scheduled.

If they decline: “No problem. How would you like to handle financing from here?” The buyer chooses the lender.

## **Connect the buyer and loan officer in Follow Up Boss**

After the buyer agrees, make the connection in their contact record.

### **Select the loan officer**

Open the contact’s Financing section and select the lender field. Choose an available ZHL loan officer or Transfer to your ZHL team.

### **Add the agreed context**

Include the purchase timing, question they want answered, and preferred contact time. Confirm the assignment, then send the group introduction.

### **Check the connection**

Confirm receipt and the call time with both people. Assignment alone does not confirm that they have spoken.

The feature requires Zillow two-way integration and your Zillow profile linked to FUB. If the option is missing, ask your administrator to check those connections.

[FUB transfer instructions](#) ■ · Reviewed September 17, 2026

## **Send an introduction that explains why they are connecting**

Sample wording for the practice case. Replace the names, goal and time with what the buyer agreed to.

Jordan, meet Casey, a loan officer with Zillow Home Loans.

Casey, Jordan is hoping to buy in the next three months and wants to understand the monthly payment and cash needed. Jordan asked me to connect you.

Jordan is free tomorrow at three. Casey, does that work for a call?

### **After sending**

Confirm that Casey received the introduction and replied about the time. Tell Jordan when the call is confirmed.

### **If there is no reply**

Contact the loan officer directly. Update the buyer at the time you promised and agree on another time if needed.

### **Save the follow-up**

Record the buyer’s permission, the introduction and the call status in FUB. Create a task to check whether the call happened.

## **Use this checklist after your next first appointment**

Decide whether the introduction fits this buyer, then record what you agreed.

## Before offering

Confirm purchase timing, whether they have a lender, and the financing question they want answered.

## If they accept

Make the introduction, confirm receipt and call timing, then create a FUB task to check the outcome.

## If you wait

Save the reason and the next agreed contact date. Revisit the introduction when their timing or need changes.

## Keep the steps and current references available

Use the agent reference after class. Practice the introduction again with a partner.

ZHL also offers refinancing to change an existing loan's rate or term, plus cash-out options. Have the loan officer compare costs, payment, loan length and total borrowing cost. [Review refinance options](#) ■

[ZHL loan options and availability](#) ■

[Pre-approval and credit-check FAQ](#) ■

[ZHL tools and support for agents](#) ■

[FUB transfer instructions](#) ■

Product information reviewed September 17, 2026. Confirm current programs and terms with the loan officer. Use Section 1 for the knowledge overview and Section 2 for timing, sample wording and the handoff checklist.

## Practice notes

Use fictional details. Write before the example, practice aloud, and retry one specific part after feedback. During a live session, submit through your own login; this printable worksheet is a backup and does not submit for you. The form follows the presenter. Submit before the class moves on, or ask the presenter to return to the question.

### What has mattered most when working with a lender?

Think about a transaction you have worked on, a home you bought, or another experience with a lender.

**What would you say or do? Explain your reason.**

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### Explain ZHL in your own words

Take thirty seconds to explain what a buyer could learn from a ZHL loan officer.

**What would you say or do? Explain your reason.**

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## How would you bring up the lender at the first appointment?

You are wrapping up the first showing. The buyer says, "I definitely want to keep looking and buy a home. I'm hoping to move in the next three months."

**What would you say or do? Explain your reason.**

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## Practice the introduction in breakout rooms

At the end of the first appointment, introduce a willing near-term buyer to a ZHL loan officer. Complete the introduction and confirm the proposed call.

**Which exact sentence or missed step did your observer ask you to improve?**

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**What did you say or do differently on the retry?**

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## Observe the assigned learner and round:

- Checks purchase timing and whether a lender is already involved
- Explains what the ZHL conversation will help the buyer understand
- Asks permission and respects the buyer's answer
- Introduces both people and confirms contact method, owner and time

Observer / learner / round / one correction / retry:

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## Review what happened in the introductions

Return to the group. Share the wording or correction that made the conversation clearer.

**What would you say or do? Explain your reason.**

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## Review after your first attempt

Use these explanations to compare your reasoning and correct any gaps. Discussion examples are coaching guidance, not automatically graded answers.

### What has mattered most when working with a lender?

Use the group's examples to introduce ZHL's service, loan options, approval process and communication tools. These are the questions to evaluate with the loan officer; no lender can promise an outcome before reviewing the buyer and property.

### Explain ZHL in your own words

The loan officer can explain loan options, payment and cash needed. An estimate is a starting point; verified financing involves supporting documents and conditions. Confirm outstanding requirements and property-specific timing before relying on the letter.

### How would you bring up the lender at the first appointment?

Ask whether they already have a lender and what they need to know about financing. Connect the introduction to their near-term purchase goal, identify Zillow Home Loans, ask permission, and confirm a contact method and time. Do not transfer them just because they attended a showing.

### Review what happened in the introductions

A clear introduction names the buyer's goal, explains what the loan officer can help answer, asks permission, and confirms the connection. For a buyer twelve months away with no request for financing help now, agree on agent follow-up. Respect a decline and record the agreed plan.

## Buyer practice cards

### Jordan • first appointment, buying within three months

*I definitely want to keep looking and buy a home. I have not spoken with a lender yet. I want to understand the monthly payment and cash I will need.*

Buyer: accept an introduction if the agent explains the reason and asks. Prefer a group text and offer tomorrow at three. Loan officer/observer: confirm that time only when asked. Give one correction and let the agent retry.

### Morgan • twelve months away

*I am only looking ahead. My job move is about a year away, and I do not need financing help right now.*

Agent: ask what sets the timing, respect that no lender help is wanted now, and agree when to revisit. Do not transfer simply to complete a referral.

### Alex • credit concern and a three-month goal

*I want to buy in the next three months, but I have a credit issue and need to understand whether I have any options.*

Agent: ask whether Alex wants a loan officer to review the options. Explain the purpose and get permission; do not promise approval or decide credit eligibility yourself.

## Taylor · already has a lender

*I already have a lender I trust, and I do not want another introduction.*

Agent: respect the decision. Ask what has already been completed and agree how you will coordinate with the chosen lender.

## What each signal means

Connection status is separate from participation. A submitted answer is separate from a completed action. A record check is separate from writing quality. Record who observed a speaking turn and who reviewed it; a peer observation or self-check is not coach sign-off. Practice readiness, quiz certification, and activation remain separate.

## After the workshop

**Live session:** closing the session creates assignments for recall within 24 hours, a fresh case in three days, and coach review in seven days. The session creator owns follow-up across the selected teams unless a different authorized coach was selected. Confirm the displayed session timezone. Due and overdue work appears in Rep; the daily digest links to work due or awaiting review.

**Self-paced study:** arrange those same checks with a coach. If there has been no relevant client opportunity, use a new fictional case and mark real-work application as not yet observed.

Keep the first attempt and correction. A useful follow-up asks whether the agent can apply the skill in another case.

## References

- Zillow Home Loans FAQ
- ZHL agent tools
- CFPB: comparing loan offers